This Property is Condemned

By Tennessee Williams

Willie is advancing precariously along the railroad track, balancing herself with both arms outstretched, one clutching an extraordinarily dilapidated doll with a frowsy blond wig. She laughs frequently and wildly and with a sort of precocious, tragic abandon.

WILLIE: Don't talk to me till I fall off. [She proceed dizzily] Take my – crazy doll- will you? [Tosses doll toward audience] I don't wanta – break her when – I fall! I don't think I can – stay on much – longer. I'm practically - off – right now! No, don't touch me. It's no fair helping. You've got to do it – all – by yourself! God, I'm wobbling! I don't know what's made me so nervous! You see that watertank way back yonder? That's where I – started – from! This is the furthest – I ever gone – without once – falling off. I mean it will be – if I can manage to stick on – to the next – telephone – pole! Oh Here I go! [She becomes completely unbalanced and rolls down the bank.]

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INTRODUCTION

The Setting: Mississippi - A nowhere town with train tracks running through it. A boarding house right next to the train tracks, which now has a big sign outside saying: THIS PROPERTY IS CONDEMNED. I'd tell you more . . . but let's face it. Willie, our main character, is a remarkable apparition – thin as a beanpole and dressed in outrageous cast-off finery. She wears a long blue velvet party dress with a filthy cream lace collar and sparkling rhinestone beads. On her feet are battered silver kid slippers with large ornamental buckles. Her wrists and her fingers are resplendent with dimestore jewelry. She has applied rouge to her childish face in artless crimson daubs and her lips are made up in a preposterous Cupids bow. She is about thirteen and there is something childlike and innocent in her appearance despite the makeup. It's her story . . . I'll let her tell it! This Property is Condemned by Tennessee Williams.

WILLIE: Skinned my knee a little. [Spits on her knee and rubs it in] Glad I didn't put my silk stockings on. The principal damage was done to my bracelet, I guess. I knocked out one of the diamonds. Where did it go?

[Give up looking for the "diamond" – notices audience again] My name's Willie. I was expected to be a boy but I wasn't. They had one girl already. Alva. She was my sister. [Looks up at the sky] It looks like everything has been swept off with a broom. Don't it? The sky is perfectly white. It's white as a clean piece of paper. But there isn't a wind. It's up too high for us to feel it. It's way, way up in the attic sweeping the dust off the furniture up there!

I bet you're wonderin' why I ain't at school. I quituated. Two years ago this winter. Grade Five A with Miss Preston. They started teaching algebra an' I didn't give a damn what X stood for so I quit. 'Sides . . . what a girl needs to get along is social training. I learned all of that from my sister Alva. She had a wonderful popularity with the railroad men.

Mama actually run off with a brakeman on the C & E. After that everything went to pieces [A train whistles far off] You hear that whistle? That's the Cannonball Express. The fastest thing on wheels between St. Louis, New Awleuns an' Memphis. My old man got to drinking. Disappeared. I guess I ought to refer his case to the Bureau

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of Missing Persons. The same as he done with mama when she disappeared.

Then there was me and Alva. Till Alva's lungs got affected. Oh, it – wasn't like death in the movies. When somebody dies in the movies they play violins. But they didn't for Alva. Naw. Not even a victrola. They said it didn't agree with the hospital regulations. She was always singin' around the house. Throwing enormous parties. This was her favorite number. [She closes her eyes and stretches out her arms in the simulated rapture of the professional blues singer. Her voice is extraordinarily high and pure with a precocious emotional timbre]

You're the only star
In my blue hea-ven
And you're shining just
For me!

This is her clothes I got on. Inherited from her. Everything Alva's is mine. (BEAT)

The principal at my old school used to say there must've been something wrong with my home atmosphere because of the fact that we took in railroad men an' some of 'em slept with my sister. She was The Main Attraction. The house is sure empty now. I still live there by myself. I'm not supposed to be but I am. The property is condemned but there's nothing wrong with it. Some county

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investigator come snooping around yesterday. I recognized her by the shape of her hat. It wasn't exactly what I would call stylish-looking. It looked like something she took off the lid of the stove. Alva knew lots about style. She had ambitions to be a designer for big wholesale firms in Chicago. She used to submit her pictures. It never worked out.

You're the only star
In my blue hea-ven . . . .

[Notices her shoes] The freight sup'rintendent has bought me a pair of kid slippers. Patent. The same as the old ones of Alva's I'm going to dances at Moon Lake Casino. All night I'll be dancing an' come home drunk in the morning! We'll have serenades with all kinds of musical instruments. [excitedly] And the sky will be white like this. White – as a clean – piece of paper . . . . I'll draw – pictures on it! Pictures of me dancing! In a pair of patent kid shoes! Yeh! Yeh! An' they'll play my favorite music! The same as Alva's

You're the only STAR --
In my blue HEA-VEN . . . .

I'll – wear a corsage! Flowers to pin on your dress at a formal affair! Rose-buds! Violets! And lilies-of-the-valley! When you come home it's withere but you stick 'em in a bowl of water to freshen 'em up. That's what Alva done. [She pauses, and in the silence the train whistles.] The Cannonball Express . . . (BEAT)

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I'm going to live for a long, long time like my sister. An' when my lungs get affected I'm going to die like she did – maybe not like in the movies, with violins playing – but with my pearl earrings on an' my solid gold beads from Memphis . . . The sky sure is white. White as a clean piece of paper.

I'm going back now. To the watertank. An' start all over again. Maybe I'll break some kind of continuous record. Alva did once. At a dance marathon in Mobile. Across the state line. Alabama.

You're the only star
In my blue heaven - (pause)
An' you're shining just –
For me!

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Tennessee Williams
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AWARDS

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